

Meeting Name:	Cabinet
Date:	6 January 2026
Report title:	Gateway 3 – Variation Decision Parks Grounds Maintenance Contract Extension
Cabinet Member:	Councillor Ellie Cumbo, Parks and Culture
Ward(s) or groups affected:	All
Classification:	Open
Reason for lateness (if applicable):	N/a

FOREWORD – COUNCILLOR ELLIE CUMBO, CABINET MEMBER FOR PARKS AND CULTURE

Our parks and open spaces are an essential part of living well in Southwark, and we know they matter to residents. Our high quality and diverse green infrastructure is also key to achieving our biodiversity and climate change aspirations as an inner-city London Borough.

The current level of service is well received by local residents and receives positive industry recognition through its Green Flag achievements and consistent Good Parks for London performance. Fundamental to this success is a good maintenance regime, which is currently provided to Southwark Council under contract. This has enabled us to achieve a good balance between cost and quality.

The current grounds maintenance contract extension is due to expire in October 2026, but with the option to extend for a further four years. In view of a number of issues, including the quality and value of current provision, a four-year contract extension is proposed, in order to ensure ongoing quality of service and to mitigate risks including market volatility. This additional extension period will ensure ongoing quality of provision and value.

RECOMMENDATION

1. That Cabinet approves the variation of the grounds maintenance contract with Quadron Services Limited, now trading as Idverde U.K Limited, for a four-year period from 3 October 2026 with an estimated annual cost of £3.289m and subject to the contract provision as set out in paragraph 20 of this report, making a total contract value of the extension period £13.156m, and a total estimated lifetime contract value of £42.5m.

REASONS FOR RECOMMENDATIONS

2. The reason for the proposed recommendation in this report is detailed in paragraphs 21-23 (*Reason for Variation*).

ALTERNATIVE OPTIONS CONSIDERED AND NOT RECOMMENDED

3. The alternative options considered to the proposed variation are set out in the section entitled Alternative Options Considered within this report at paragraphs 27-28.

POST DECISION IMPLEMENTATION

4. Once the recommendation within this report has been approved, the following will take place:
 - i. Next steps aligned to the future proposals for this service are set out in paragraphs 24-26 of the report.
 - ii. The timeline for implementation of the actions in this report is within the project plan within the body of the report at paragraph 30.
 - iii. The planned contract management and monitoring regime is detailed out in paragraphs 35-42 of this report.

BACKGROUND INFORMATION

5. Government policy increasingly recognises the importance of greenspace in people's health and wellbeing for promoting good health, prevention of poor health and treatment and recovery from illness and injury. The government's 25-Year Environment Plan, 'A green future: Our 25-year plan to improve the environment' acknowledges the essential role that the natural environment and greenspace play in people's physical and mental health and aims to improve population health and wellbeing by forging a closer connection between people and the natural environment.
6. The council's parks and open spaces play an essential part in improving the quality of life for residents. As an inner-city London Borough, high quality and diverse green infrastructure is also very important environmentally and is considered a significant contributor to residents' well-being and also to supporting the delivery of the council's climate emergency targets.
7. The provision and upkeep of parks and open spaces remain a strategic priority for the council, and this has been demonstrated through the large injection of capital funding into infrastructure for parks over the past decade. Southwark's parks are increasingly popular and are enjoyed by growing local populations.

8. The council has ensured that its parks provision remains a high priority. This has ensured that green spaces remain able to contribute positively to the wider health and wellbeing agenda and the quality of life of local residents. There are also economic benefits as a green borough is attractive to live and work in, which boosts the local economy.
9. The current level of parks service is well received by local residents and has positive industry recognition through its Green Flag achievements (all 30 Green Flags retained again in 2024) and Good Parks for London performance. The quality of provision was formally recognised in 2022, with the council being awarded the title of 'Best Parks in London'. Fundamental to this success is a good maintenance regime, which is provided to the council through the Grounds Maintenance (GM) contract. This has enabled the achievement of a good balance between cost and quality.
10. The GM contract was awarded to Quadron Idverde for an initial period of seven-years (3 October 2016 – 2 October 2023) with the option to extend for a further period or periods of up to seven years.
11. The GM contract was extended in October 2023 for a period of three-years (see Background Documents: Gateway 3 – Variation Decision Parks Grounds Maintenance Contract Extension) to ensure service stability and to maintain quality.
12. The GM contract includes the option to extend by a further four years. The estimated value of the GM contract for financial year 2025-26 is £3,432,283. The total original contract value and current extension have a combined value of £29,344,000. The current contract spend from October 2016 to October 2025 is £27,803,547.
13. The GM contract provides a year-round service and is borough-wide covering 105 sites including five major parks, 33 local parks, 15 gardens and squares, two sports grounds, three cemeteries, five adventure playgrounds and 42 other open spaces. Contract quantities indicate a total asset measurement of around 300 hectares under management (as of October 2025).
14. The primary items covered by the GM contract include grounds maintenance (all gardening tasks), cleansing and weed control of hard surfaces and the opening and locking of some parks. Also included are an emergency out-of-hours provision, park-keeping services (including room booking facilitation) plus bin emptying, litter picking, faeces, drug and sex litter removal. The contract includes an apprenticeship programme and provision of staff to support coaching sessions at the specialised BMX cycling centre in Burgess Park, green waste composting and re-use and volunteering programmes in conjunction with friends and stakeholder groups.

15. The contract is output-based with individual programmed elements of work priced against a bill of quantities. There are also priced schedules of rates to facilitate any required ad-hoc works.
16. As part of the original procurement strategy in 2016, the council made a capital investment of £1.2m to service the costs of plant and machinery associated with the contract. During the initial seven-year term Idverde was responsible for repair, maintenance and replacement of vehicles and machinery under the terms of a Chattel Lease with the council. However, on the commencement of the first extension period in October 2023 the Chattel Lease expired with all responsibility for vehicles and machinery transferring back to the council. In advance, a growth bid of £750k was allocated by the council which is currently being unlocked as the original machinery reaches end of life and requires replacement. All new machinery is estimated to be replaced by June 2026. Vehicle provision is now being transitioned to a leasing arrangement with Idverde as this provides greater value for money than purchase and will be completed by April 2026.
17. Further detail with reference to parks grounds maintenance vehicles and machinery procurement, leasing and environmental considerations is set out in Gateway 1 Report – Procurement of machinery for Parks Grounds Maintenance Contract (background papers).

Contract highlights summary

18. An overview and some of the contract highlights between 2016 and 2025 include:
 - high public satisfaction, supported by ongoing volumes of compliments and low number of complaints
 - Internal client team monitoring scores consistently exceeding 90% target (see Contract management and monitoring, paras 35-42)
 - Independent external validation – 30 Green Flag parks and top ten performing London borough 2019-25 (Good Parks for London)
 - Quality green infrastructure supporting the physical and mental health of residents
 - Welcoming, safe and well-maintained landscapes supporting passive and active recreation and sport
 - 81% of sites of importance for nature conservation (SINCs) in positive management, ranking Southwark fifth in England on this national indicator.

Previous savings

19. Please refer to the closed version of this report.

KEY ISSUES FOR CONSIDERATION

Key Aspects of Proposed Variation

20. Please refer to the closed version of this report.

Reasons for Variation

21. In 2016 there were enough suitably-sized grounds maintenance suppliers in the marketplace to ensure a competitive marketplace. It is apparent, however, that due to the current economic landscape, high London living wages and business operational costs that there is now a much-reduced supplier base.
22. The current provider Idverde has consistently demonstrated high quality performance delivery for the lifetime of the contract to date. This reflected in positive customer satisfaction feedback, stakeholder engagement and contractual performance reporting.
23. The reason for variation is to exercise the option to extend the current contract as outlined in this report and as summarised in paragraph 20 above on the basis of value for money and the most recent benchmarking data.

Future Proposals for this Service

24. Sufficient time has been allocated to a full comprehensive service review during the proposed contract extension period to plan for a new procurement or the transition to other new arrangements.
25. A Gateway Zero – Strategic Options Assessment is timetabled for Cabinet review in June 2029.
26. The above review with an associated procurement timetable allow for a sufficient period of mobilisation for new arrangements prior to a start date in October 2030.

Alternative Options Considered

27. Alternative options considered are set out in Appendix 1. Officers considered the available options for this service in the autumn of 2024:
- Undertaking a new procurement exercise
 - Bringing the service in-house
 - Managing the service through a Local Authority Trading Organisation (LATCO)
 - Extending the current contract for a period of up to a further four years (in whole or in part)
28. A high-level RAG rated options appraisal is included as appendix 1, this considers all the benefits and risks associated with each option. On

balance, taking into account all issues, it is felt that a further service extension was the most appropriate way forward to:

- Ensure that the current level of grounds maintenance provision will continue, with no risk of interrupted or reduced service quality through a new contractor
- Ensure stability during a time of significant economic market turbulence, the contract price could be guaranteed, with an additional negotiated reduction in the contract sum, as part of the agreed extension package.

Identified risks for the Variation

29. Please refer to the closed version of this report.

Procurement project plan (Key Decision)

30.

Activity	Completed by/Complete by:
Briefed relevant cabinet member (over £100k)	27/11/2025
DCRB Review Gateway 3:	05/11/2025
CCRB Review Gateway 3:	20/11/2025
CMT Review Gateway 3:	25/11/2025
Notification of forthcoming decision – despatch of Cabinet agenda papers	29/11/2025
Approval of Gateway 3 Report	06/01/2026
End of Scrutiny Call-in period and notification of implementation of Gateway 3 decision	20/01/2026
Contract Variation Enacted	02/10/2026
Amend Contract Register	01/10/2026
Contract amendment start	02/10/2026
Contract completion date	01/10/2030

Policy implications

31. A healthy environment is one of the Southwark 2030 six goals. In order to achieve this, the council seeks, where possible to improve or increase greenspace and biodiversity for the community to enjoy. This means taking a proactive approach to rewilding underused green space and converting non-green spaces by roads and in estates to community gardens, parklets and other forms of green community space.

32. The council's declaration of a climate emergency and current carbon neutrality commitments drives the need to ensure that the future grounds maintenance service supports this commitment through associated targets as set out in the Climate Change Action Plan. Associated initiatives include the Southwark Nature Action Plan (SNAP) and ongoing capital programme tree-planting commitments.
33. The Environment Act 2021 strengthened the 'Biodiversity Duty' required of public authorities under the Natural Environment and Rural Communities Act (NERC) 2006. Under the strengthened duty, the council has a statutory obligation to 'consider' what it can do to both 'conserve and enhance' biodiversity.
34. The Southwark 2030 Procurement Framework mandates the inclusion of Social Value within all council contracts. This is supported by the Social Value Framework which provides the methodology for securing, evaluating, monitoring, and reporting activity from our supply chain.

Contract management and monitoring

35. The council's contract register publishes the details of all contracts over £5,000 in value to meet the obligations of the Local Government Transparency Code. The Report Author must ensure that all appropriate details of this procurement are added to the contract register via the eProcurement System.
36. The contract will continue to be managed by the Parks, Trees and Ecology Manager with support from the Parks Management Team.
37. The council monitors the provider's performance against a range of measures including a mixture of nationally determined Audit Commission and locally determined council Indicators and measures.
 - Monitoring Statistics (including an assessment of the authorised officer's inspection results and number of rectification and default notices issued)
 - Management Systems (including an assessment of the provider's management of the contract, quality control measures, provision of information, complaint handling and operation of asset management systems)
 - Resources (including an assessment of the provider's resources allocated to the contract including staffing levels and equipment provision in terms of availability and sufficiency)
 - Production and scrutiny of an annual performance review report with reference to the above.
38. Based on the total number of points awarded with the above indicators the provider is placed in one of three possible Performance Bands as follows:
 - Green: Score 9 to 10 Points, at this standard the provider is performing to expectations and no intervention is required.

- Amber: Score 7 to 8 Points, at this standard, the provider is not yet meeting expectations and will prepare a rectification plan for discussion at the joint council and provider operational meetings setting out the corrective action necessary to improve performance to the Green standard.
- Red: Score 0 - 6 Points, at this standard, the Provider is performing below an adequate standard, and the Council will issue a Warning Notice.

39. The Key Performance Indicator of overall contract quality is proposed to remain at 90% annually despite the operational savings proposed to be applied to the service. Operational savings will be mitigated through a restructure of contracted staff through reorganisation, training and development.
40. Since the start of the GM contract, Idverde's contract performance has exceeded the agreed annual performance target of 90%, with a current average performance score of 93%. It is also clear through the last public satisfaction survey and ongoing compliments and limited complaints, that customers are very happy with the current service.
41. A healthy professional relationship also exists between the council and Idverde and was demonstrated through the substantial support provided by the contract staff during the Covid-19 pandemic and continued flexibility where contract adjustments have been required.
42. External independent measurement of the quality of parks also takes place through the Green Flag scheme. Southwark currently has 30 parks with this status (the second highest in London). In addition, the Good Parks for London annual assessment has placed Southwark's parks in the top ten in London for the last six years, with Southwark being the top performing London borough in 2022.

Community, equalities (including socio-economic) and health impacts

Community impact statement

43. Maintaining high quality standards of grounds maintenance across our parks and greenspaces will have a positive impact on the community. Actions for the conservation and promotion of biodiversity promote community cohesion by connecting people with nature, providing volunteering opportunities, and fostering positive interactions between people from different communities. Much of the wildlife assets of the council are in parks and public spaces, free to all users, and accessible year-round.
44. The council has developed regular volunteering with business and community volunteers and will continue to promote volunteering in our open spaces. This includes opportunities with schools, people with disabilities, and underrepresented groups.

45. Implementing the recommended option in this report will have no detrimental impact on any group or those with protected characteristic as outlined in the Equality Act 2010 or the Public Sector Equality Duty (PSED).
46. Many activities to conserve and enhance biodiversity provide novel opportunities for participation with physical activity for members of the public, increasing representation in outdoor activities and promoting resident health and wellbeing. Access to nature is well documented as beneficial to both mental and physical health.
47. Parks benefit the health of communities through improving air quality, reducing urban temperatures, reducing noise and calming traffic, managing flood risks, and providing amenity value, recreation space and cultural services.

Equalities (including socio-economic) impact statement

48. Section 149 of the Equality Act 2010 imposes a general equality duty on public authorities (the PSED in the exercise of their functions), to have due regard to the need to:
 - Eliminate discrimination, harassment and victimisation and any other conduct that is prohibited by or under the Equality Act 2010
 - Advance equality of opportunity between people who share a relevant protected characteristic and people who do not share it
 - Foster good relations between people who share a relevant protected characteristic and people who do not share it.
49. For the purposes of the PSED the following are “protected characteristic” considerations:
 - Age
 - Marriage and civil partnership
 - Disability
 - Gender reassignment
 - Pregnancy and maternity
 - Race
 - Religion or belief
 - Sex
 - Sexual orientation
50. The PSED and its implications for groups with protected characteristics using the council's parks and open spaces will be considered further as the parks and grounds maintenance service is developed and delivered.
51. In line with the PSED full equalities impact assessments are undertaken when designing, consulting on and delivering parks projects and programmes, and ensuring mitigation is in place.

Health impact statement

52. Years of scientific study show a positive link between nature and good mental and physical health. Through connecting with nature, appreciating it and building a relationship with the natural environment the benefits are most profound. Connecting with nature can:
- Reduce stress, anxiety, depression and fatigue
 - Boost immune systems
 - Encourage people to be more physically active and
 - It may reduce the risk of chronic disease.

Climate change implications

53. Conserving and enhancing biodiversity through good parks and open spaces management can reduce emissions and mitigate against the impacts of climate change, for example, trees both sequester carbon and provide shade.
54. Continuing good maintenance of our parks will directly contribute to the Council's Climate Change Strategy and Action Plan, which commits to a 'Thriving Natural Environment' and an adapted, resilient borough. These commitments include improving biodiversity, introducing new green corridors, making our streets a green place to walk, play and relax and increasing tree canopy cover across the borough. The Action Plan for the strategy includes 14 SMART actions for the 'Thriving Natural Environment' priority area.
55. A £1m allocation for capital projects for green space enhancements and biodiversity improvements was agreed in 2022 in response to Climate Change Citizen Jury recommendations, which will contribute to both climate change and biodiversity objectives. The majority of these enhancements and improvements are situated within parks.
56. The resilience and adaptation elements of the Climate Strategy, defines the council's approach to responding to the harmful effects of a changing climate. Actions resulting from the delivery of the strategy will offer opportunities for biodiversity improvements through new green infrastructure and sustainable urban drainage to tackle flooding and overheating. This also includes the following targets and goals:
- Review the current approach to the use of pesticides in the public realm to better protect residents, wildlife and promote biodiversity
 - Identify potential green corridors between key green spaces/Sites of Importance for Nature Conservation
 - Parks, gardens and green spaces are adapted to be drought resistant.
57. The council's recent and ongoing investment in parks vehicles and machinery will increase the provision of new vehicles and equipment with modern green engines across the life of the contract extension period.

58. Waste recycling management will also be reviewed prior the commencement of the extension arrangements in 2030 in collaboration with Waste Management colleagues and term supplier Veolia.

Social Value considerations

59. The Public Services (Social Value) Act 2012 requires that the council considers, before commencing any procurement process, how wider social, economic and environmental benefits that may improve the wellbeing of the local area can be secured. Social value considerations and how the delivery of these services can benefit the local area are below:
- Third sector management of key sites of importance for nature conservation
 - Community participation/volunteering
 - Opportunities for educational engagement
 - Local employment and supporting contract opportunities.
60. In terms of added value, the contract facilitates an apprenticeship programme with five places available at any one time. In addition, there is also provision for volunteer opportunities, joint projects with friends and stakeholders, corporate volunteer days and community payback schemes.
61. Social considerations are to be built into the contract variation for delivering the recommended option, the contractors are expected to:
- guarantee the payment of at least the London Living Wage (LLW) for contracted staff and any subcontractors used in the delivery of the service
 - follow all relevant standard provisions on blacklisting
 - follow the standards for financial transactions and payment windows for their entire supply chain
 - make every effort to reflect the council's Fairer Future Vision principle by 'looking after every penny as if it was our own'.
62. Please refer to the closed version of this report.

Economic considerations

63. Inflationary pressures and the cost-of-living crisis had significant impacts on the economy and commercial businesses nationally. The green industry which predominantly employs lower paid semi-skilled workers has been struggling for several years now to both recruit and retain staff, especially for jobs in central London, where pay has failed to keep pace with living and commuting costs. As the current cost of living crisis continues, it is unlikely that the availability of a competitive marketplace and available staff will become more abundant in the short term.
64. This report considers an appropriate delivery model for the provision of parks grounds maintenance services. The provision of this service

already exists and therefore no significant impacts to the local economy are anticipated.

65. The procurement exercise associated with this recommendation takes into consideration how the delivery of these services can benefit the local area in consideration of the Southwark 2030 Procurement Framework, For example, through:

Local contractors

- All of the options currently presented have opportunities to engage local supporting contractors
- All of the options have opportunities to vary and expand third sector management participation.

Apprenticeships/internships

- Idverde further engage with the council's apprenticeship model
- Apprenticeships are to continue to be monitored through monthly, quarterly and annual performance meetings.

Social considerations

66. The council continually recognises the benefit of working closely with its local communities to improve and increase the use of its parks and greenspaces. That work is developed in partnership with residents, third sector groups, volunteer networks and other important stakeholders to maximise the health and wellbeing benefits of visiting parks for residents.
67. Community engagement; further engagement with leading workdays with Friends of Groups, corporate volunteers, community payback, and educational placements to be monitored through monthly, quarterly and annual performance meetings.

Environmental/Sustainability considerations

68. No additional impacts are envisaged to result from the contract extension.
69. The new machinery purchased to service the contract extension period has been benchmarked against the leading environmentally friendly items available in the market.
70. Replacing existing 2016 purchased fleet with new leased vehicles with the latest efficient engines will reduce total emissions produced servicing the contract extension period.
71. Idverde will further engage with the council's biodiversity initiatives in increasing the number of enhanced ecologically managed spaces as the transition from ornamental to biodiverse management in parks grounds maintenance continues.

Financial Implications

72. Please refer to the closed version of this report.

Legal Implications

73. Please see concurrent from the Assistant Chief Executive – Governance and Assurance.

Consultation

74. None.

Other implications or issues

75. N/a.

SUPPLEMENTARY ADVICE FROM OTHER OFFICERS

Strategic Director of Resources (FC25/006)

76. Please refer to the closed version of this report.

Head of Procurement

77. Please refer to the closed version of this report.

Assistant Chief Executive – Governance and Assurance (SB041225)

78. Please refer to the closed version of this report.

BACKGROUND PAPERS

Background Papers	Held At	Contact
GW2 Contract Award for the parks grounds maintenance service	Parks & Natural Environment	Julian Fowgies 07925 637218
Link: https://moderngov.southwark.gov.uk/documents/g5372/Public%20reports%20package%20Tuesday%2019-Jul-2016%2016.00%20Cabinet.pdf?T=10		
GW3 Final Cabinet Open Version – Parks Grounds Maintenance Contract Extension 7 March 2023	Parks & Natural Environment	Julian Fowgies 07925 637218
Link: Report template - contract award approval		

Background Papers	Held At	Contact
Delegated Officer Decision Gateway 1 Report – Procurement of machinery for Parks Grounds Maintenance Contract	Parks & Natural Environment	Julian Fowgies 07925 637218
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APPENDICES

No	Title
Appendix 1	GM Contract Future Service Options Appraisal (From October 24)
Appendix 2	Equality Impact and Needs Analysis – Grounds Maintenance Contract Variation

AUDIT TRAIL

Cabinet Member	Councillor Ellie Cumbo, Parks and Culture		
Lead Officer	Aled Richards, Strategic Director of Environment, Sustainability and Leisure		
Report Author	Julian Fowgies, Parks, Trees & Ecology Manager		
Version	Final		
Dated	15 December 2025		
Key Decision?	Yes		
CONSULTATION WITH OTHER OFFICERS / DIRECTORATES / CABINET MEMBER			
Officer Title	Comments Sought	Comments included	
Strategic Director of Resources	Yes	Yes	
Head of Procurement	Yes	Yes	
Assistant Chief Executive – Governance and Assurance	Yes	Yes	
Cabinet Member	Yes	Yes	
Contract Review Boards			
Departmental Contract Review Board	Yes	Yes	
Corporate Contract Review Board	Yes	Yes	
Cabinet Member	Yes	Yes	
Date final report sent to Constitutional Team		10 December 2025	

GM Contract Future Service Options Appraisal (From October 24)

APPENDIX 1

Option No.	Service Stream	Cost	Benefits	Risks	Rating (RAG)
1.	New external procurement	Price would be determined by market, currently impacted by the broader economic environment. A significant increase would be expected due to inflationary factors	• An opportunity to re-write the specification. • Ability to build in mechanisms for future efficiencies the start of the contract	• Service price and quality vulnerable to both industry and broader national & global economic impacts. • Goes against the preferred approach for service delivery – i.e. insourcing where possible • A risk of a higher cost & reduced quality. • Client resource impacts - heavy procurement process • Transition period service impacts • Losing control of known price and quality outputs	Amber
2.	Bringing the service in-house	Increase in current costs (estimated at circa 15-30%, but would require further investigation)	• Meets the Council's preference for internalised services • Control	• Potential for higher cost of staff • Liabilities for repair of machinery and vehicles • Short-term client officer resource impacts • Recruitment and retention of GM staff • Significant resource required re TUPE implications for circa 90 x staff	Amber
3.	LATCO	Increase in current costs estimated at circa 15-20%,	• Specific focus equipped to develop bespoke services • Potential to develop commercial culture & services	• No organisational experience of creating LATCO • Unknown financial pressures present risk to LATCO • Under the Companies Act 2006 – directors to act in best interest of company rather than the council	Amber
4.	Extension of the current contract	Known costs with extension adjustments	• No transition impacts • Known costs and quality • Consistency of high-quality service • Designs out the potential for additional industry & broader economic impacts	• Limited flexibility around future additional savings, as these will be front loaded and pre-agreed,	Green



APPENDIX 2

Equality Impact and Needs Analysis – Grounds Maintenance Contract Extension

Guidance notes

Things to remember:

Under the Public Sector Equality Duty (PSED) public authorities are required to have due regard to the aims of the general equality duty when making decisions and when setting policies. Understanding the effect of the council's policies and practices on people with different protected characteristics is an important part of complying with the general equality duty. Under the PSED the council must ensure that:

- Decision-makers are aware of the general equality duty's requirements.
- The general equality duty is complied with before and at the time a particular policy is under consideration and when a decision is taken.
- They consciously consider the need to do the things set out in the aims of the general equality duty as an integral part of the decision-making process.
- They have sufficient information to understand the effects of the policy, or the way a function is carried out, on the aims set out in the general equality duty.
- They review policies or decisions, for example, if the make-up of service user changes, as the general equality duty is a continuing duty.
- They take responsibility for complying with the general equality duty in relation to all their relevant functions. Responsibility cannot be delegated to external organisations that are carrying out public functions on their behalf.
- They consciously consider the need to do the things set out in the aims of the general equality duty not only when a policy is developed and decided upon, but when it is being implemented.

Best practice guidance from the Equality and Human Rights Commission recommends that public bodies:

- Consider all the [protected characteristics](#) and all aims of the general equality duty (apart from in relation to marriage and civil partnership, where only the discrimination aim applies).
- Use equality analysis to inform policy as it develops to avoid unnecessary additional activity.
- Focus on the understanding the effects of a policy on equality and any actions needed as a result, not the production of a document.
- Consider how the time and effort involved should relate to the importance of the policy to equality.
- Think about steps to advance equality and good relations as well as eliminate discrimination.
- Use good evidence. Where it isn't available, take steps to gather it (where practical and proportionate).
- Use insights from engagement with employees, service users and others can help provide evidence for equality analysis.

Equality analysis should be referenced in community impact statements in Council reports. Community impact statements are a corporate requirement in all reports to the following meetings: the cabinet, individual decision makers, scrutiny, regulatory committees and community councils. Community impact statements enable decision makers to identify more easily how a decision might affect different communities in Southwark and to consider any implications for equality and diversity.

The public will be able to view and scrutinise any equality analysis undertaken. Equality analysis should therefore be written in a clear and transparent way using plain English. Equality analysis may be published under the council's publishing of equality information, or be present with divisional/departmental/service business plans. These will be placed on the website for public view under the council's Publications Scheme. All Cabinet reports will also publish related

Equality analysis should be reviewed after a sensible period of time to see if business needs have changed and/or if the effects that were expected have occurred. If not then you will need to consider amending your policy accordingly. This does not mean repeating the equality analysis, but using the experience gained through implementation to check the findings and to make any necessary adjustments.

Engagement with the community is recommended as part of the development of equality analysis. The council's Community Engagement Division and critical friend, the Forum for Equality and Human Rights in Southwark can assist with this (see section below on community engagement and www.southwarkadvice.org.uk).

Whilst the equality analysis is being considered, Southwark Council recommends considering Socio-Economic implications, as socio-economic inequalities have a strong influence on the environment we live and work in. As a major provider of services to Southwark residents, the council has a legal duty to reduce socio-economic inequalities and this is reflected in its values and aims. For this reason, the council recommends considering socio-economic impacts in all equality analyses, not forgetting to include identified potential mitigating actions.

Section 1: Equality impact and needs analysis details

Proposed policy/decision/business plan to which this equality analysis relates		Gateway 3 Report – Extension of the Grounds Maintenance Contract (3 years) – Oct 23 – Oct 26			
Equality analysis author		Tara Quinn			
Strategic Director:		Caroline Bruce			
Department		Environment & Leisure		Division	Parks & Leisure
Period analysis undertaken		November 2022 (Ongoing)			
Date of review (if applicable)		November 2025 (Dec 2025 update - review not required as no change)			
Sign-off		Position		Date	

Section 2: Brief description of policy/decision/business plan

1.1 Brief description of policy/decision/business plan

The current contract was awarded to Idverde for a seven year period (3rd October 2016 – 2nd October 2023). The contract facilitates the option to extend for up to a further seven year period, or indeed pursue an alternative service option.

The contract provides a 365 day per year service and is borough-wide covering some 105 sites including five major parks, 33 local parks, 15 gardens and squares, two sports grounds, three cemeteries, five adventure playgrounds and 42 other open spaces. Contract quantities indicate a total asset measurement of around 300 ha under management (March 2022).

The primary items covered by the contract include grounds maintenance (all gardening tasks). Cleansing and weed control of hard surfaces. Opening and locking of parks. Out of hours service cover provision. Park keeping services including room booking facilitation. Bin emptying, litter picking and faeces and needles removal. Apprenticeship programme and BMX coaches. Green waste composting & re-use. Volunteering programme(s) and close working with friends and stakeholder groups.

Officers considered the available options for this service from October 2023:

- Undertaking a new procurement exercise
- Bringing the service in-house
- Extending the current contract for a period of up to 7 years (in whole or in phases)

An options analysis was undertaken and on balance it was determined that a 3 year extension of the current contract was the most appropriate way forward.

Section 3: Overview of service users and key stakeholders consulted

2. Service users and stakeholders	
Key users of the department or service	The maintenance service covers all parks across the borough but does not provide direct services to the public and is not bookable. The service facilitates the provision of safe and presentable green spaces for both passive and active recreation, sports and leisure.
Key stakeholders were/are involved in this policy/decision/business plan	The decision relates to the extension of an existing service only, with no significant change to existing service levels. Accordingly, involvement has been limited to the Council's standard Procurement Gateway decision making process. Cabinet Members & Internal Business Units • Parks & Leisure • Procurement • Legal • Finance

Section 4: Pre-implementation equality impact and needs analysis

This section considers the potential impacts (positive and negative) on groups with 'protected characteristics', the equality information on which this analysis is based and any mitigating actions to be taken, including improvement actions to promote equality and tackle inequalities. An equality analysis also presents as an opportunity to improve services to meet diverse needs, promote equality, tackle inequalities and promote good community relations. It is not just about addressing negative impacts.

The columns include societal issues (discrimination, exclusion, needs etc.) and socio-economic issues (levels of poverty, employment, income). As the two aspects are heavily interrelated it may not be practical to fill out both columns on all protected characteristics. The aim is, however, to ensure that socio-economic issues are given special consideration, as it is the council's intention to reduce socio-economic inequalities in the borough. Key is also the link between protected characteristics and socio-economic disadvantage, including experiences of multiple disadvantage.

Socio-economic disadvantage may arise from a range of factors, including:

- poverty
- health
- education
- limited social mobility
- housing
- a lack of expectations
- discrimination
- multiple disadvantage

The public sector equality duty (PSED) requires us to find out about and give due consideration to the needs of different protected characteristics in relation to the three parts of the duty:

1. Eliminating discrimination, harassment and victimisation
2. Advancing equality of opportunity, including finding out about and meeting diverse needs of our local communities, addressing disadvantage and barriers to equal access; enabling all voices to be heard in our engagement and consultation undertaken; increasing the participation of underrepresented groups
3. Fostering good community relations; promoting good relations; to be a borough where all feel welcome, included, valued, safe and respected.

The PSED is now also further reinforced in the two additional Fairer Future For All values: that we will

- Always work to make Southwark more equal and just
- Stand against all forms of discrimination and racism

Age - Where this is referred to, it refers to a person belonging to a particular age (e.g. 32 year olds) or range of ages (e.g. 18 - 30 year olds).

Potential impacts (positive and negative) of proposed policy/decision/business plan; this also includes needs in relation to each part of the duty.	Potential Socio-Economic impacts/ needs/issues arising from socio-economic disadvantage (positive and negative)
No specific impacts identified	No specific impacts identified
Equality information on which above analysis is based	Socio-Economic data on which above analysis is based
Maintenance service only, no change to existing provision	Maintenance service only, no change to existing provision
Mitigating and/or improvement actions to be taken	
N/A	N/A

Disability - A person has a disability if s/he has a physical or mental impairment which has a substantial and long-term adverse effect on that person's ability to carry out normal day-to-day activities.

Please note that under the PSED due regard includes:

Giving due consideration in all relevant areas to "the steps involved in meeting the needs of disabled persons that are different from the needs of persons who are not disabled include, in particular, steps to take account of disabled persons' disabilities." This also includes the need to understand and focus on different needs/impacts arising from different disabilities.

Potential impacts (positive and negative) of proposed policy/decision/business plan; this also includes needs in relation to each part of the duty.	Potential socio-economic impacts/ needs/issues arising from socio-economic disadvantage (positive and negative)
No specific impacts identified	No specific impacts identified
Equality information on which above analysis is based	Socio-economic data on which above analysis is based
Maintenance service only, no change to existing provision	Maintenance service only, no change to existing provision

Mitigating and/or improvement actions to be taken	
N/A	N/A

Gender reassignment: - The process of transitioning from one gender to another. Gender Identity: Gender identity is the personal sense of one's own gender. Gender identity can correlate with a person's assigned sex or can differ from it.	
Potential impacts (positive and negative) of proposed policy/decision/business plan; this also includes needs in relation to each part of the duty.	Potential socio-economic impacts/ needs/issues arising from socio-economic disadvantage (positive and negative)
No specific impacts identified	No specific impacts identified
Equality information on which above analysis is based.	Socio-economic data on which above analysis is based
Maintenance service only, no change to existing provision	Maintenance service only, no change to existing provision
Mitigating and/or improvement actions to be taken	
N/A	N/A

Marriage and civil partnership – In England and Wales marriage is no longer restricted to a union between a man and a woman but now includes a marriage between a same-sex couples. Same-sex couples can also have their relationships legally recognised as 'civil partnerships'. Civil partners must not be treated less favourably than married couples and must be treated the same as married couples on a wide range of legal matters. (Only to be considered in respect to the need to eliminate discrimination.)	
Potential impacts (positive and negative) of proposed policy/decision/business plan	Potential socio-economic impacts/ needs/issues arising from socio-economic disadvantage (positive and negative)
No specific impacts identified	No specific impacts identified

Equality information on which above analysis is based	Socio-economic data on which above analysis is based
Maintenance service only, no change to existing provision	Maintenance service only, no change to existing provision
Mitigating or improvement actions to be taken	
N/A	N/A

Pregnancy and maternity - Pregnancy is the condition of being pregnant or expecting a baby. Maternity refers to the period after the birth, and is linked to maternity leave in the employment context. In the non-work context, protection against maternity discrimination is for 26 weeks after giving birth, and this includes treating a woman unfavorably because she is breastfeeding.	
Potential impacts (positive and negative) of proposed policy/decision/business plan; this also includes needs in relation to each part of the duty.	Potential socio-economic impacts/needs/issues arising from socio-economic disadvantage (positive and negative)
No specific impacts identified	No specific impacts identified
Equality information on which above analysis is based	Socio-economic data on which above analysis is based
Maintenance service only, no change to existing provision	Maintenance service only, no change to existing provision
Mitigating and/or improvement actions to be taken	
N/A	N/A

Race - Refers to the protected characteristic of Race. It refers to a group of people defined by their race, colour, and nationality (including citizenship) ethnic or national origins. N.B. Gypsy, Roma and Traveller are recognised racial groups and their needs should be considered alongside all others

Potential impacts (positive and negative) of proposed policy/decision/business plan; this also includes needs in relation to each part of the duty.	Potential socio-economic impacts/ needs/issues arising from socio-economic disadvantage (positive and negative)
No specific impacts identified	No specific impacts identified
Equality information on which above analysis is based	Socio-economic data on which above analysis is based
Maintenance service only, no change to existing provision	Maintenance service only, no change to existing provision
Mitigating and/or improvement actions to be taken	
N/A	N/A

Religion and belief - Religion has the meaning usually given to it but belief includes religious and philosophical beliefs including lack of belief (e.g. Atheism). Generally, a belief should affect your life choices or the way you live for it to be included in the definition.	
Potential impacts (positive and negative) of proposed policy/decision/business plan; this also includes needs in relation to each part of the duty.	Potential socio-economic impacts/ needs/issues arising from socio-economic disadvantage (positive and negative)
No specific impacts identified	No specific impacts identified
Equality information on which above analysis is based	Socio-economic data on which above analysis is based
Maintenance service only, no change to existing provision	Maintenance service only, no change to existing provision
Mitigating and/or improvement actions to be taken	
N/A	N/A

Sex - A man or a woman.

Potential impacts (positive and negative) of proposed policy/decision/business plan; this also includes needs in relation to each part of the duty.	Potential socio-economic impacts/ needs/issues arising from socio-economic disadvantage (positive and negative)
No specific impacts identified	No specific impacts identified
Equality information on which above analysis is based	Socio-economic data on which above analysis is based
Maintenance service only, no change to existing provision	Maintenance service only, no change to existing provision
Mitigating and/or improvement actions to be taken	
N/A	N/A

Sexual orientation - Whether a person's sexual attraction is towards their own sex, the opposite sex or to both sexes	
Potential impacts (positive and negative) of proposed policy/decision/business plan; this also includes needs in relation to each part of the duty.	Potential socio-economic impacts/ needs/issues arising from socio-economic disadvantage (positive and negative)
No specific impacts identified	No specific impacts identified
Equality information on which above analysis is based	Socio-economic data on which above analysis is based
Maintenance service only, no change to existing provision	Maintenance service only, no change to existing provision
Mitigating and/or improvement actions to be taken	
No mitigating actions are currently required	

Human Rights

There are 16 rights in the Human Rights Act. Each one is called an Article. They are all taken from the European Convention on Human Rights. The Articles are The right to life, Freedom from torture, inhuman and degrading treatment, Freedom from forced labour, Right to Liberty, Fair trial, Retrospective penalties, Privacy, Freedom of conscience, Freedom of expression, Freedom of assembly, Marriage and family, Freedom from discrimination and the First Protocol

Potential impacts (positive and negative) of proposed policy/decision/business plan

The contract extension and continuation of grounds maintenance services will have no impact on the articles that are set out in the Human Rights Act.

Information on which above analysis is based

Maintenance service only, no change to existing provision

Mitigating and/or improvement actions to be taken

No mitigating actions are currently required

Conclusions

Summarise main findings and conclusions of the overall equality impact and needs analysis for this area:

No impacts were identified through this exercise mainly due to the maintenance related work type and detached public interface. It was considered prudent however to ensure the ongoing consideration of EQIA issues to inform future key decisions around the service, via the formalised procurement and governance processes.

Section 5: Further equality actions and objectives

5. Further actions			
Based on the initial analysis above, please detail the key mitigating and/or improvement actions to promote equality and tackle inequalities; and any areas identified as requiring more detailed analysis.			
Number	Description of issue	Action	Timeframe
1	EQIA update	Review prior to future key decision(s)	November 2025

5. Equality and socio-economic objectives (for business plans)			
Based on the initial analysis above, please detail any of the equality objectives outlined above that you will set for your division/department/service. Under the objective and measure column please state whether this objective is an existing objective or a suggested addition to the Council Plan.			
Objective and measure	Lead officer	Current performance (baseline)	Targets
			Year 1
Future assessments will be undertaken as part of the procurement governance process and considered in conjunction with the associated Gateway report.			

6. Review of implementation of the equality objectives and actions	
There are no equality actions and objectives that require implementation at this point in time. This will remain under review and considered when making future key decisions around the service.	
